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Alleged Trump jet ruse ‘surreal’

Report says threat from Iran spurred sudden plane swap

ASSOCIATED PRESS

President Donald Trump secretly flew out of last month's NATO summit in Ankara, Turkey, on an alternate military aircraft while the White House made it appear that the Republican president was flying on a jet used as Air Force One, according to a report by The Washington Post.

The Post said Monday the operation was prompted by an Iranian assassination threat against Trump. The ruse was carried out as journalists and some White House staff members were led to believe they were on the same plane as the president as he began his journey back to Washington from the annual gathering of NATO country leaders.

The Post cited material reviewed by the newspaper, a U.S. official familiar with the operation and another person with knowledge of the president's travel.

The Associated Press has not independently confirmed the report.

Trump had flown to the summit in a new Qatari-gifted and retrofitted red, white and navy jet.

But ahead of departing Turkey, he said he would fly partway home on an older-model baby blue Air Force One plane instead.

The president at the time said the new luxury jet was being flown out ahead of his departure from Ankara to give some U.S. troops based

See **TRUMP** on Page A5**More tornadoes:** Two twisters add to Illinois record amid wild, gusty storms**Sweeping outages:** Hundreds of thousands lose power in region, ComEd says

ANOTHER BLOW



Omar Gomez, from left, Jasmine Arnold and Jen Arnold carry a limb from their yard Tuesday in Lansing. VINCENT D. JOHNSON/FOR THE DAILY SOUTHTOWN

By Lila Hempel-Edgers, Rebecca Johnson and Evgenia Anastasakos
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Extreme weather usually doesn't scare Mary Beth Uretz, but she spent Tuesday morning crying in her Homewood basement, clutching her pets as the storm pounded.

"Psychologically, it's a lot to deal with," said Uretz. "I've never gone to bed at night and worried about my house fall-

ing over, until this summer."

Indeed, severe storms swept through a broad swath of the Chicago area Tuesday, tearing down trees, power lines and property alike. Hundreds of thousands of ComEd customers lost power and thousands of flights were delayed at the city's airports.

Weather officials confirmed Tuesday night that two tornadoes had touched down during the storms, one in southern Cook County and another in east-

ern Will County. Officials said they were still surveying the extent of damage, and a challenging survey environment was prolonging the process.

These storms came after another round tore through the region over the weekend and a year with a record-breaking number of tornadoes.

One person died in a structure fire in Portage, Indiana, during the storms. Local police said there was an extended response time due

to the "hazardous conditions." The cause of the fire remains under investigation.

In Homewood, officials reported "significant storm damage" from what is believed to be a tornado that touched down just before 11 a.m. Downed power lines, large trees and debris blocked roadways and nearly 70% of the town lost power, officials said.

Uretz initially didn't

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200

Illinois is nearing 200 tornadoes on the year, and may pass the mark once surveying of Tuesday's storms is complete. Experts say the pace is not normal. The state averaged 54 twisters a year between 1990 and 2020.

INSIDE



CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

For Sox fans, it's time to believe

Rich Benzik, of Dwight, Illinois, fixes his pope hat before the start of a White Sox game at Rate Field in Chicago on Tuesday. The team's promotion honoring its most famous fan makes believers out of everyone, writes Paul Sullivan. **Sports**

CURBS FOR DATA CENTERS: Mayor Brandon Johnson signed an order Tuesday directing city departments to intensify scrutiny of the fast-growing facilities. **Chicagoland, Page A3**

CEO appealed to mayor over grant, records show

In unusual move, nonprofit Acclivus copied Johnson on email for CDPH

By Alice Yin
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A politically connected nonprofit at the center of a dispute with Mayor Brandon Johnson's health department appealed to the mayor while competitively bidding for millions in city anti-violence funding, records show.

Acclivus Inc. CEO LeVon Stone sent then-Chicago Department of Public Health Commissioner Dr. Olusimbo Ige a "Notice of Protest" letter on Nov. 25, 2024, and copied Johnson on it, according to a copy obtained by the Tribune through a Freedom of Information Act request. The correspondence came five days after Johnson's

campaign donated \$25,000 to the community violence intervention group and a week before the deadline for organizations to apply for the city grant money.

Ige's past quarrel with the group before she was pushed out of her job spurred controversy this week following a Tribune report over her complaints that Acclivus tried to circumvent city protocols and use its close ties to the mayor and his team to help make its case for city grant funding.

It's unusual to copy the mayor himself on a protest about a standard request for proposal. The mayor's staff and representatives from Acclivus have both said they followed the city's procure-

ment guidelines.

Stone's November 2024 complaint called on the Health Department to rescind its RFP, arguing the language was written to let a single lead grantee control the entire funding allocation.

"Concentrating power in a central agency will limit community voice in decision-making, including allocation of violence prevention funds, and subsequently will hinder community capital building," Stone said. "The top-down approach proposed here falls short of challenging on-going structural racism within systems, and to do so replicates the trauma and disconnection that systems-involved families in need of assistance have experienced over generations."

See **ACCLIVUS** on Page A10

Feds: Man shot by cops during ATF sting was misidentified

By Jason Meisner
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

An unarmed man shot by a Chicago police officer during an ATF-led firearms sting in Country Club Hills

was misidentified in now-dismissed federal charges in June as one of the gunmen who allegedly tried to rob the agents, the U.S. attorney's office now says.

A criminal complaint

made public Tuesday charged a new suspect, Dontrell Gordon, with participating in the June 9 incident, which resulted in two people being shot by law enforcement, including Demond Edwards.

In an unusual footnote in the 13-page complaint against Gordon, the U.S. attorney's office said Edwards had been incorrectly identified in previous charges as one of the people who had approached

the undercover agents' car during the undercover operation dressed in all black and with weapons drawn.

Further investigation has determined that person was actually Gordon, according to

the charges.

The new charges were the latest development in a case that erupted in controversy two months ago

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